



AFP PHOTO / VIKTOR DRACHEV

CONSUMER BOOM: Russians are partying hard knowing that they have a tomorrow

NOWHERE ARE THE SIGNS OF THE NEW Russia more evident than in Moscow. Long rows of glitzy malls and luxury apartments have replaced the dull rows of Soviet-style tenements. The young flaunt ultra mini skirts, tattooed body parts and Mohawk style haircuts.

on, change by the day. Ask Alla Manilova, the exuberant minister in the St. Petersburg Government, what has changed and her one word answer is, "everything." She believes that more has happened in the past 18 years to Russia than in the past 200 years of its history. For her, the most important change is that, "a new generation that has no idea of what it was to live in the Soviet Union, is born totally free. They are now free even to evolve their own ideologies."

Religion, forbidden under the communist regime, has made a major comeback. In most cities, onion-domed cathedrals are being repaired and expanded with Sunday churchgoers swelling in numbers. Swearing in ceremonies, including that of Presidents, are now conducted in the presence of the cardinals and their blessings actively sought by politi-

cians. Putin wears a cross around his neck and this is what apparently endeared him to US President George Bush when he first met the Russian leader in 2001. It prompted Bush to say about Putin, "I was able to get a sense of his soul," and declare that he is, "an honest, straightforward man." Later on he would describe Putin as, "One cool dude." Their personal friendship endured despite Putin, last year, outlining a new aggressive Russian foreign policy that denounced the Iraq war, continued business with Iran, challenged America's missile defence plans and warned NATO countries against inducting Ukraine, a former Soviet republic, as a member.

More than God, Russians seem to have rediscovered their faith in themselves. "We are passing through a period of absolute contentment," observes Dmitri Kosyrev, the

ALLA Y. MANILOVA

Minister, St. Petersburg Government

"The new generation has no idea of the Soviet era. They are born free and can evolve their own ideology."

VLADIMIR P. EVTOUSHENKOV

Chairman, Sistema

"We can't be copy cats. We must revive fundamental sciences as nothing was done for 15 years."